



Photograph by SYED ZUBAIR; Hair and makeup by DIPTHI AASHOK



## QUICK STARTER

**Meena Ganesh**

44, CEO, Tesco Hindustan Service Centre

In the beginning Meena Ganesh dreamed of becoming a nuclear scientist. It was a passion that saw her study physics, but by the time she graduated, Ganesh had changed her mind. After an MBA at IIM-Kolkata, the CEO of Tesco Hindustan Service Centre (HSC) realised that the thrill and excitement of start-ups was calling out to her. After building up NIIT, then PricewaterhouseCoopers and Microsoft India, Ganesh set up CustomerAsset with her husband K. Ganesh. It was one of India's pioneering BPO companies. "That industry didn't really exist. It was something we conceived of and was a huge opportunity," she says. It was sold to ICICI OneSource for over \$20 million. Ganesh doesn't regret the decision. After all, her next assignment at Tesco promised bigger challenges. One that involved starting HSC and helping an organisation reinvent itself from an IT standpoint, she says. And who better to do it than the start-up queen herself?

**FIRST INVESTMENT** We bought a house in Gurgaon, Haryana, in 1986.

**WORST FINANCIAL DECISION I MADE AND THE LESSON LEARNT** One of our property investments in Noida turned out to be a dud. We didn't do an antecedent check to see if the approvals were in place. We lost our entire money. By the time we finished our research and were ready to invest again, the real estate prices had gone up.

**PROPERTY WATCH** B-class cities are something to watch out for. Affluence is spreading and there is good quality property available. For instance, there are good properties available outside Bangalore. But one also needs to know what the property will be used for.

**BIGGEST INDULGENCE** A Mercedes C class

**FAVOURITE GETAWAY** In Spain, places like Barcelona or Ibiza.

**USE  
THIS  
TIP**

"SECURE YOUR FOUNDATION AND FIGURE OUT WHAT YOUR SHORT-MEDIUM AND LONG-TERM GOALS ARE, TO AVOID PITFALLS LATER."